

The Persistence of and Influences on Baby Names

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1. Introduction

This report explores the persistence in baby name trends, as well as the potential influence of popular culture on these trends. This informs the factors that should be considered when naming characters of children's toys

1.1. Spearman Rank Correlation

The time-series representations below depict the rank correlations of baby names in the US from 1910-2014. It seems that boy names are more persistent than girls names. It does appear that after the 1990's, names become less persistent, with the correlations becoming smaller. The persistence in name trends has fallen for both girl and boy names over time, however, trends seem to persist longer still for boy names.

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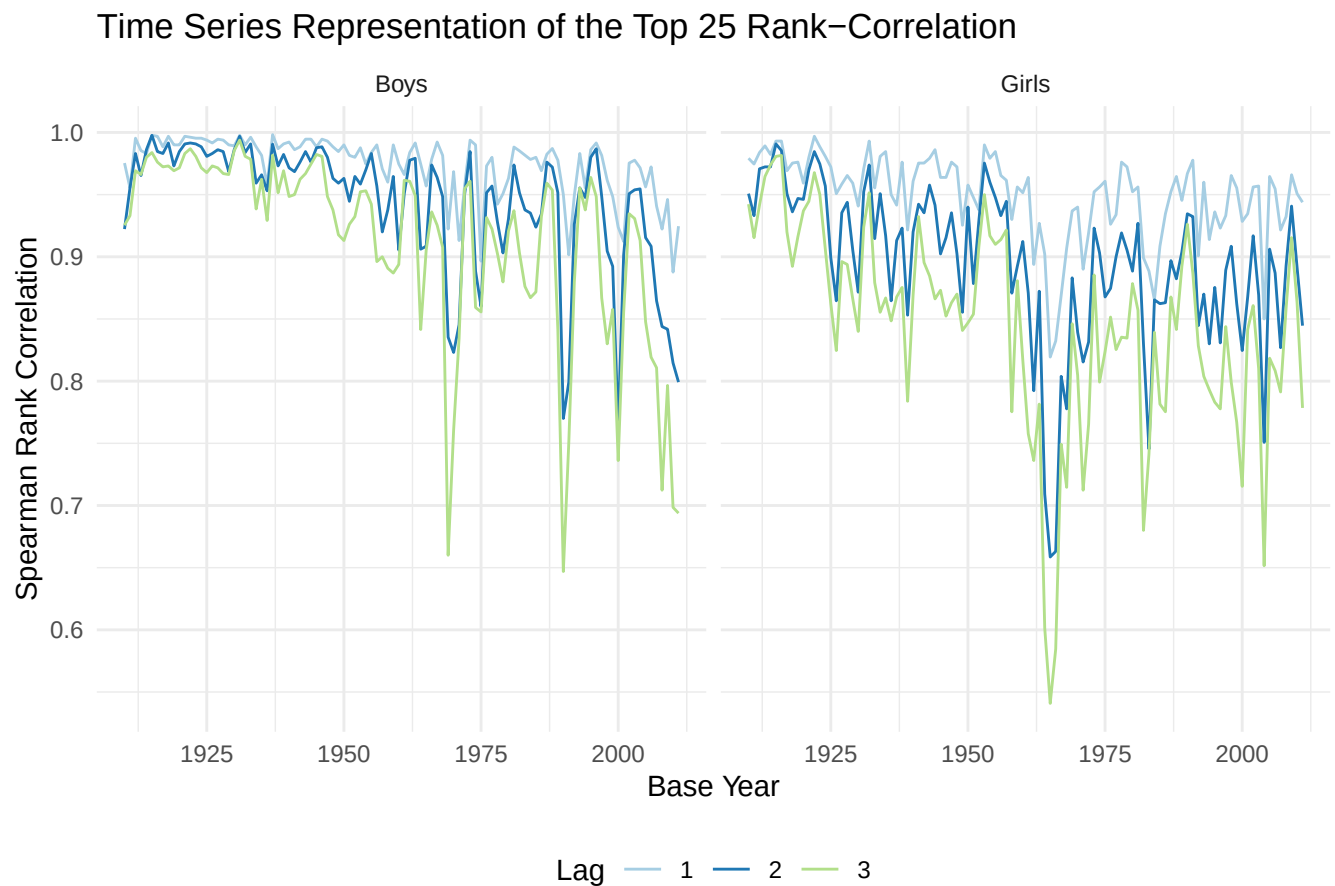


Figure 1.1: Spearman Rank Correlation.

1.2. Surges in Names

Only 24% of the names have experienced a year-on-year surge greater than 5000% between 1910-2014 are boy names. The plot below inspects the popularity of the name “Mallory” over time. “Mallory” spiked in 1983 following the 1982 premiere of “Family Ties” that included the character, Mallory Keaton. It’s popularity dulled over the years, illustrating the influence of popular culture on baby names.

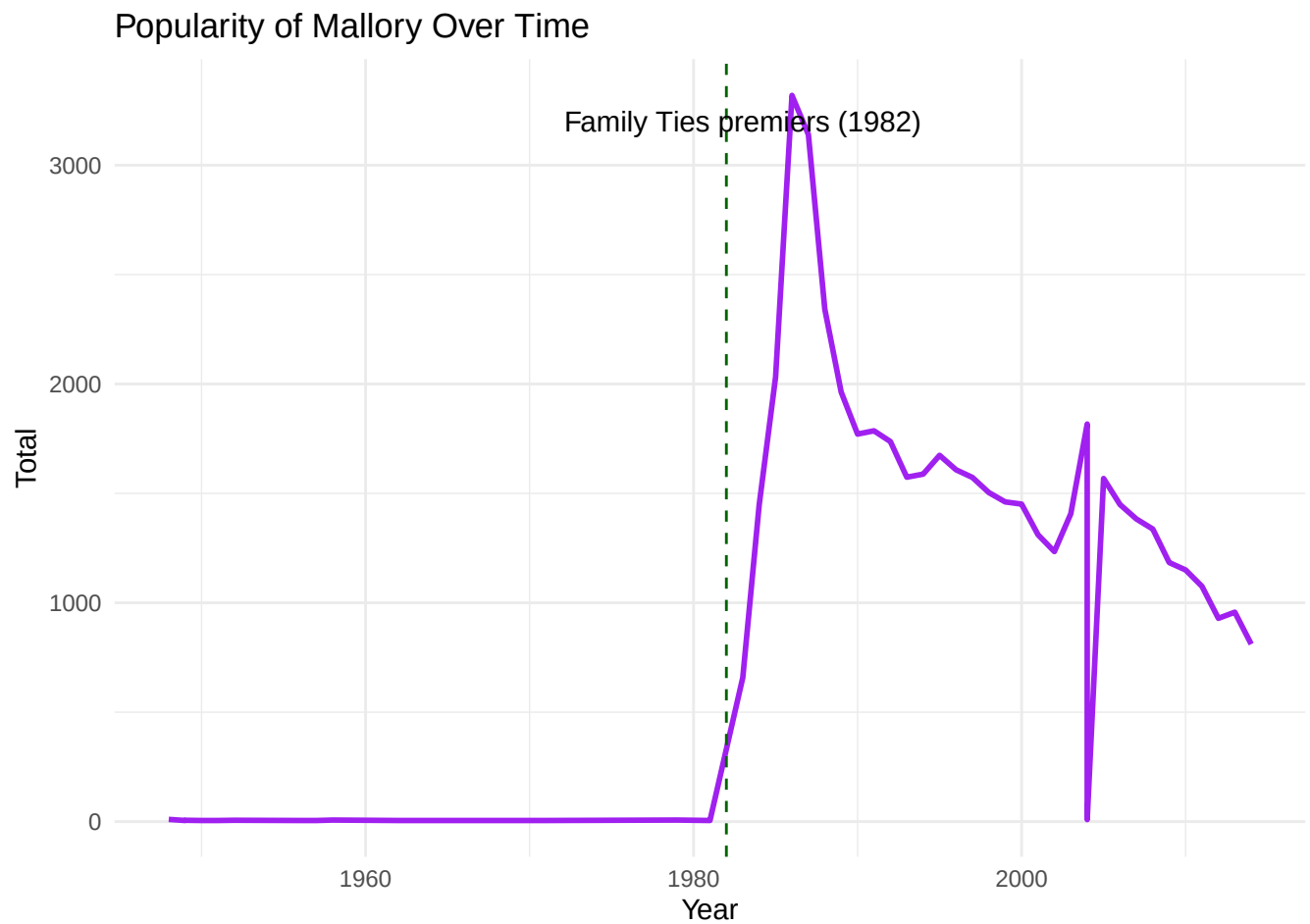


Figure 1.2: Mallory Popularity Over Time.

1.3. Name Trends: Jude

According to the Billboard Hot 100, The Beatles's hit song, "Hey Jude", was charting for 19 weeks between 1968 and 1969. Further, the credits for popular films reveal that Jude Law stardom may also drive interest in this gender neutral name. These two case studies depict the impact of the media in naming conventions

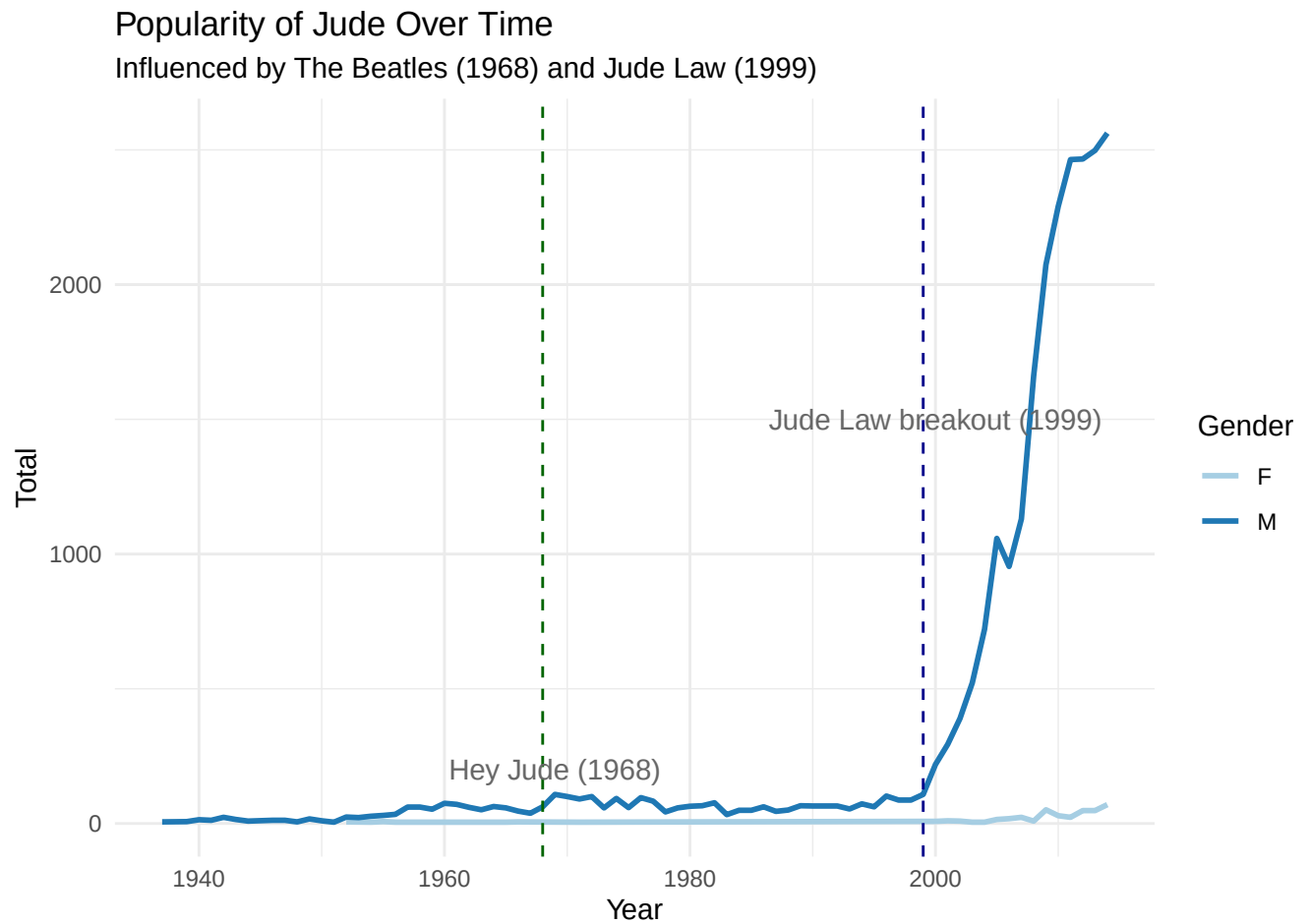


Figure 1.3: Jude Popularity Over Time.

2. Conclusion

Baby name trends are increasingly less persistent. This means that toy names must quickly adapt, especially those marketed towards girls. To stay on top of the trends, popular media must be studied. Through analysing song charts and IMDb ratings, the company can stay inline with the curve.